

Morning Routine
By Ryan Wilbert

Punch Up

I don't even have a physical calendar
On my wall but I'll punch
At the hollow drywall
Waiting until I see a little crack
Watch my watch wind backup
Clicking back to start
Do it again and again

I finally won!

Tomorrow brings tomorrow
One over the next
Hopscotch, leapfrog, whatever you
Called it in your youth
Punch at the ball until it bounces
In the right square
Punch at the pens at rest on your
Desk waiting to spell something out
Hole punches of *save this for later*
Punch at the thought I can't hold for
Long enough until it punches through

The membrane keeping it up there
Punch at the dreams I cannot leave
Beating me to pieces
Left hook, nice jab
Every single FUCKING night

There's a punch-up at the wedding
Of what used to exist, what can never
Come back and
What is stepping on your
Newly polished shoes while
A drunken man in the back
Punches up his fists

Stop it!

Stop it!

Stop it!

Ah, fuck, I've lost

I am punching at nothing until I see something like a
Fly hanging in front of me or a loose strand of hair
And only there do I realize swinging my fists so hard
Over and over with every move I replay from the start
Is foolish when I stand in the center of the ring with
Ropes of time at my disposal to change.

Heart and Hill

Dylan Thomas once wrote that his
Blood runs like a heart and hill
But some days I think it is more
of

a

mountain

Determined to pull the carpet out from

Under my feet

Trip over rocks, scratch up

My boots

Throw my gear over the

Edge

Tug on my rope

Rattle my heart around my chest

Without grace, without a fair

Beating.

My heart threatens to chew off

Arteries

Or dry up my bones

Wailing like a child not

Getting what it wants

This isn't an attack,

It threatens,

More of a

Preplanned assault

You're out of time, think fast!

Take another step

Not knowing which one will be

Your last before you go to bed

One final time

Drifting into the loud realm of

Regret

Why did you not speak clearly?

Why did you not show off?

At the face of familiar

Conversation

My heart demands it's own surgical removal

But refuses to say much

Against the rush of truth.

My heart does not believe
It is deserving
Of sending it out of the park
Cracking a bat with
My full weight
Until I finish up my game
Pick up a brush and
Craft a picture-perfect
Painting of the mountain I'll
Put aside, eventually,
Laughing it off as a long
Forgotten hurdle
I finally beat—
Hiding underneath its frame is
A mound of trash, a fire hazard
You'd hate for anyone to see
If you aren't settled
Like a heart at the bottom
Of the hill.

Boys are good at breaking things

Ceiling tile dust coating the carpet proves this well.

I saw a group of them pull up a rolling chair

To get up there to try and fix it

Screw in the outlet and convince the RA

Beer cans and dead vape pens

Materialized out of thin air–

It couldn't possibly be theirs–

Filling the hole,

Ignoring what happened the night before

Don a backwards cap like it's a crown

Declare themselves king of the hall,

Bringing rapture with their nightly storms,

Army pounding against the walls

Breaking my brief moment of

Rest I attempt to complete.

Boys are good at damaging

Look no further than the state of the bathroom.

Blades once swung to ventilate the chamber

And stall doors squealed loudly

On this fine morning, though,

Silence sounds too loud and the
Lights are timid, hidden in the shadows,
Watching as I wipe sticky hands against moist towelettes
(Built-up heat condenses on the counter tops
Dryest thing in the room is my skin)
Flicking water against the glass frame
Covering up what lies under.
I can't blame the boys down the hall for this one—
Mirror has not one crack—but
Brown bottles in my periphery still taunt
Shatter *shatter* *shatter me*
All the same
I shut my eyes before I ruin my peace.

I am good at destroying things.
Reaching for my toiletries,
Too busy predicting what I should do next and
Regretting what I haven't done,
I scrape against my razor blade
Cutting open my finger and
Spilling my blood all
Down the drain–
Watching a sole droplet of water
Drip from chin to chest
I realize what a waste, it is,
To spoil over nothing, for something I've yet to live
Trying to excuse it is as something we all do
It's my nature and I must follow through
On ruining anything before it begins.